IF

there was a turning point in the Aryan Khan case, it came on November 12 last year, on his 24th birthday. Aryan, the eldest son of Bollywood superstar Shah Rukh Khan, had been summoned that day for questioning by the Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB). The SIT had been formed to conduct an independent probe of the charges of possession and consumption of illicit drugs against Aryan and 19 others—a case prepared by the NCB's zonal directorate, then headed by the flamboyant Sameer Wankhede.

A month earlier, Wankhede had led the raid that resulted in the sensational arrest of Khan when he and five friends were boarding cruise ship *Cordelia* at the Mumbai port on October 2. The NCB zonal team claimed that they had seized a substantial quantity of illicit drugs from them and others who were to board the cruise ship and that Aryan had links with an international drugs syndicate. Had the charges been proven, punishment for Khan under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, 1985, could have ranged from six months to 20 years of rigorous imprisonment.

However, as Wankhede waded into a series of controversies involving his own probity as well procedural lapses in the conduct of the Aryan Khan case, NCB chief S.N. Pradhan decided he needed an independent probe to ascertain the truth. "The Wankhede saga," he says, "was overtaking the Aryan Khan one and, in both cases, the NCB's reputation was at stake. So, I decided to form an SIT to go into the Aryan case apart from initiating a special vigilance enquiry into the allegations against Wankhede."

These two decisions by Pradhan would set in motion a major process that would see the NCB take the rare and courageous decision of admitting it had made a mistake in indicting Aryan and five others involved in the *Cordelia* cruise case and chargesheeting the 14 others who were apprehended. The NCB admitted that its Mumbai unit had erred gravely in its investigation and that it would take stern action against errant officials, including Wankhede. Such a move would bring discredit to the NCB but also usher in a much-needed course correction in its functioning that could eventually redeem its reputation. "It would strengthen our determination to focus on the big fish in the drugs business rather than chase lesser offences. It will do enormous good to our fight against drug trafficking," Pradhan told INDIA TODAY in an interview (see '*Go after the big fish rather than consumers*').

WHY THE CHARGES AGAINST ARYAN KHAN WERE DROPPED

Aryan Khan was detained on October 2, 2021, when he was about to board the Goa-bound *Cordelia* cruise ship along with long-time friend Arbaaz Merchant and a few acquaintances. He was arrested the next day by the Narcotics Control Bureau's (NCB) Mumbai unit, then helmed by zonal director Sameer Wankhede, on charges of possession and consumption of drugs under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act of 1985. Punishment for the offences is rigorous imprisonment for anything between six months and 20 years. Here are the major reasons why the Special Investigation Team (SIT) headed by Sanjay Singh of the NCB dropped the charges against him:

POSSESSION OF DRUGS

↘ While Wankhede's team had not found any drugs in Aryan's possession, it initially charged